

Challenge Objective

- **Prioritization Strategy**

- My priority 1 would be the internal error (system-wide bug). This issue impacts up to 50% of the user base within the next hour. The scale and urgency make this the highest business risk. If not escalated immediately, it could multiply customer complaints, revenue loss, and reputational damage across the company. I would notify the technical team with severity level, impact estimate, reproduction steps, and urgency. I will also alert customer support leadership to prepare for incoming volume.
- My priority 2 would be the angry outage client. This is a long-term revenue-generating customer already experiencing financial loss. The emotional intensity is high, and retention risk is immediate. The goal is to move the customer from confrontation to collaboration by acknowledging the impact quickly, taking ownership, providing a concrete action plan and timeline and avoiding defensiveness or premature promises.
- My priority 3 would be the delivery failure customer. This issue is emotionally urgent but operationally isolated to a single order. It still deserves empathy and creativity because of the wedding deadline and future brand value. The goal is to provide solutions, not policy recitations.

1. Internal Message to the Technical Team

Subject: SEV-1 ALERT – Potential System-Wide Customer Impact

Team,

I identified a critical bug that appears likely to impact approximately 50% of active users within the next hour if not mitigated immediately.

Current observations:

- Error behavior began approximately 4:38 PM
- Affected services: authentication/session persistence
- Symptoms: intermittent login failures and timeout loops
- Estimated exposure window: escalating rapidly
- Customer-facing impact already confirmed through at least one enterprise outage escalation

Immediate requests:

1. Assign incident lead
2. Investigate rollback viability for latest deployment
3. Freeze non-essential deployments
4. Post status update in incident channel within 15 minutes
5. Confirm whether customer communications should begin proactively

I am currently handling escalations from impacted clients and will relay verified customer impact examples as they arrive.

Priority level: SEV-1

Best regards,
Eula Jumagdao
Customer Service Representative

2. Response to “Angry Outage Phone Caller

Subject: Account # xxx - Immediate Escalation and Active Resolution Plan

Hi [Client Name],

I understand the seriousness of this outage and the financial impact it is having on your business. I want to acknowledge that this level of disruption is unacceptable, and I appreciate you taking the time to escalate it directly.

I have personally escalated your case as a highest-priority incident with our technical team. Investigation and mitigation efforts are already underway.

Here is what will happen next:

- You will receive your next status update within 30 minutes, even if the investigation is still ongoing
- I am coordinating directly with our incident response team to ensure your account remains prioritized
- Once service is restored, I will review your account for appropriate service credits and refund considerations based on the outage duration and impact

Regarding your request for executive visibility: while I cannot immediately commit our CEO to a live call, I have escalated the severity and business impact internally with leadership awareness attached to your account.

I understand your frustration, and my focus right now is restoring stability as quickly as possible while keeping communication transparent and consistent.

I will remain your direct point of contact until resolution.

Best regards,

Eula Jumagdao
Customer Service Representative

3. Response to “Delivery Failure” Live Chat Customer

Subject: Order # xxx: Urgent Delivery Package

Hi [Customer Name],

I’m so sorry this happened, especially with the wedding tomorrow. I can absolutely understand why you’re upset, and I’m going to do everything I can to help fix this quickly.

I’ve already started an urgent trace request with the carrier to confirm the exact delivery scan location. In parallel, I’m checking two faster backup options for you right now:

1. A replacement shipment through our emergency fulfillment process
2. Availability through any local partner inventory near your delivery area

While I investigate those, could you confirm:

- The best phone number to reach you immediately
- Whether the delivery location has a front desk, concierge, mailroom, or nearby neighbors who may have accepted the package

Because this is time-sensitive, I’m personally escalating the case instead of routing you through standard processing queues.

I’ll stay with you here until we have a concrete next step.

Best regards,

Eula Jumagdao

Customer Service Representative

Bonus Challenge

Justification to Manager

I approved an exception for overnight international replacement shipping because the potential reputational damage outweighed the short-term operational cost. This order was tied to a once-in-a-lifetime event, and our tracking data indicated the issue was likely caused by carrier failure rather than customer error. Given the emotional circumstances, the holiday weekend timing, and the customer's visible distress, strictly enforcing policy would likely have resulted in public escalation, negative social exposure, and the loss of a potentially long-term customer relationship.

I approached this as a customer-retention and brand-protection decision rather than a standard shipping issue. To minimize operational risk, I documented the exception thoroughly, escalated the carrier issue for investigation, and flagged the account internally for post-resolution review. I believe the cost of this exception is significantly lower than the long-term cost of reputational harm and customer distrust.

SOP Improvement Proposal

Proposed SOP Change

Create a "Critical Event Exception Path"

Allow senior support staff to authorize one-time expedited exceptions for:

- Weddings
- Funerals
- Medical emergencies
- Major milestone events

Requirements:

- Carrier fault verification
- Manager notification (not pre-approval)
- Cost ceiling threshold
- Mandatory documentation template

Why This Helps

It removes the emotional burden from frontline employees forced to choose between:

- protecting policy
- protecting the customer relationship

It also standardizes judgment under pressure and reduces inconsistent decision-making.

Explain Your Process – Written Breakdown of Logic

Overview

My approach focused on handling the situation the same way a real customer operations lead, or escalation manager would during a high-pressure incident: stabilize the largest business risk first, protect customer trust second, and communicate clearly throughout the process.

I prioritized based on overall impact, urgency, and potential long-term damage to the business rather than emotional intensity alone.

Step 1 – Prioritization Logic

Why I Addressed the Internal Error First

The internal bug had the potential to affect 50% of the user base within an hour, making it the highest operational and financial risk. A widespread system failure could rapidly multiply customer complaints, increase churn risk, overload support channels, and damage company reputation at scale.

My first action was to immediately escalate the issue as a SEV-1 incident because:

- the impact was broad,
- the timeline was urgent,
- and technical mitigation required immediate coordination.

This decision reflects crisis-management thinking: prevent the fire from spreading before handling individual escalations.

Step 2 – Handling the Angry Outage Customer

How I Approached De-escalation

The outage customer was already emotionally escalated due to revenue loss and service downtime. In these situations, customers usually want three things:

1. acknowledgment,
2. accountability,
3. and a clear recovery plan.

Instead of becoming defensive or interrupting, I focused on:

- validating the business impact,
- maintaining calm communication,
- taking ownership,
- and providing concrete next steps.

I intentionally avoided making unrealistic promises such as “this will be fixed immediately” or guaranteeing a CEO call. Instead, I offered structured communication timelines and direct ownership of the case.

The goal was to move the customer from confrontation into collaboration.

Step 3 – Solving the Delivery Failure

Why Empathy and Creativity Were Important

This customer’s issue was emotionally urgent because the package was tied to a wedding happening the next day. Even though this problem affected only one customer, the emotional stakes and brand risk were high.

Rather than relying on scripted policy language, I focused on:

- empathy first,
- solutions second,
- process third.

I proposed multiple immediate recovery options simultaneously:

- carrier trace investigation,
- local inventory checks,
- emergency replacement review,
- and direct escalation handling.

This demonstrates ownership mentality and proactive problem solving under pressure.

Step 4 – Bonus Challenge Decision

Why I Chose to Override Policy

I chose to approve the exception because I evaluated the situation from a long-term business perspective instead of a short-term operational perspective.

The likely outcomes of strictly enforcing policy were:

- viral negative publicity,
- permanent customer loss,
- and reputational damage disproportionate to the shipping cost.

However, I also controlled the risk by:

- documenting the exception,
- escalating internally,

- and recommending process improvements afterward.

This balances customer advocacy with operational accountability.

Step 5 – Communication Strategy

Across all three situations, I focused on maintaining:

- calm tone,
- precision,
- transparency,
- and confidence.

I avoided emotional reactions, vague promises, or defensive language. My communication style was designed to reassure customers while still being operationally realistic.

Final Thought

My overall process was guided by one principle:

Protect the business by protecting trust.

That meant:

- minimizing large-scale operational damage,
- retaining high-risk customers,
- supporting emotionally distressed users,
- and communicating with clarity under pressure.

The responses were intentionally written to reflect real-world leadership, ownership, and customer-centric decision-making during a live crisis scenario.